

TELL

Re-Telling the Patient's Story



ROBERT LUBY, MD

APPLYING FUNCTIONAL MEDICINE IN CLINICAL PRACTICE

Disclosures

Robert Luby, MD, disclosed no relevant financial relationships with any ineligible companies.

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Learning Objectives

At the conclusion of this segment, successful participants will be able to:

1. Explain how re-telling the patient's story can develop and strengthen the therapeutic partnership and improve outcomes.

IFM Clinical Skills and Performance Objectives

THIS SEGMENT WILL ENABLE PARTICIPANTS TO DEVELOP & APPLY THESE SKILLS IN THEIR PRACTICE:

1. Re-tell the patient's story, explaining how the underlying root causes have contributed to their current concerns and clinical findings.
2. As you re-tell the story, show the timeline to the patient to indicate correlations among their individualized root causes, clinical findings, and current concerns.
3. After re-telling the story, ask the patient to correct and add to the story to ensure a shared understanding.

GOTOIT Functional Medicine Framework

G

GATHER oneself and clinical indicators on the IFM Functional Medicine Timeline.

O

ORGANIZE clinical indicators and imbalances on the IFM Functional Medicine Matrix.

T

TELL the patient's story to ensure a shared understanding.

O

ORDER and prioritize interventions feasible for the patient.

I

INITIATE referrals, evaluative tests, and therapeutic modalities.

T

TRACK and adjust evaluative and therapeutic regimens.

Long Description: GO TO IT Functional Medicine Framework

- The G O T O I T Functional Medicine Framework
- G – Gather oneself and clinical indicators on the I F M Functional Medicine Timeline
- O – Organize clinical indicators and imbalances on the I F M Functional Medicine Matrix
- T – Tell the patient's story to ensure a shared understanding
- O – Order and prioritize interventions feasible for the patient
- I – Initiate referrals, evaluative tests, and therapeutic modalities
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Long Description: GO TO IT Functional Medicine Framework

- The G O T O I T Functional Medicine Framework with an emphasis on T for tell the patient's story to ensure a shared understanding

Clinical Focus:

- Description of and rationale for the Tell step of the GOTOIT method.



The Functional Medicine Clinical Method

GOTOIT:

The six steps of the functional medicine clinical method

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Tell

Tell the life story back to the patient to ensure accuracy and a shared understanding.

This dialogue, *focused on the timeline*, highlights how the factors elicited in the Gather step may have contributed to current or future clinical findings, concerns, health status, and trajectory.

The patient is asked to join in correcting and amplifying the story, engendering a context of true partnership.

The Therapeutic Encounter

- Four key themes are:
 - Elicit “what matters to the patient?”
 - Therapeutic listening
 - Responding to patients’ emotions and unmet needs
 - Patient centeredness and therapeutic engagement

How practitioners encourage a sense of partnership, empowerment, respect, and trust can shape patients’ perspectives.

We can start with how we re-tell the patient’s story.

- El-Abidi K, Moreno-Poyato AR, Cañabate-Ros M, et al. The therapeutic relationship from the perspective of patients and nurses in the first days of admission: a cross-sectional study in acute mental health units. *Int J Ment Health Nurs*. 2024;33(1):134-142. doi:10.1111/inm.13227
- Kornhaber R, Walsh K, Duff J, Walker K. Enhancing adult therapeutic interpersonal relationships in the acute health care setting: an integrative review. *J Multidiscip Healthc*. 2016;9:537-546. doi:10.2147/JMDH.S116957

The Essential Steps of “Tell”

- Thank the patient for sharing their story and acknowledge their goals.
- Explain that you will re-tell their story to ensure a shared understanding.
- While showing the timeline, correlate the antecedents, triggers, and mediators to the patient’s current concerns and conditions.



GOTOIT

The sequence of steps used in the practice of functional medicine:

GOTOIT Step and Definition	IFM Tools (examples)	Clinical Actions
G – GATHER oneself with a brief personal practice prior to prepare for each patient encounter. Take a detailed functional medicine history that includes the essential health events and features of a patient's life documented on the IFM Timeline in the process of organizing the patient's data.	• Cultivating Self Awareness and Mindfulness • Adult Intake Form • Medical Symptom Questionnaire (MSQ) • PROMIS Questionnaires • Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal • Functional Medicine Tree • Functional Medicine Timeline	• Use the Cultivating Self-Awareness and Mindfulness document to help gather yourself before every patient encounter. • The Adult Intake Form is used to gather initial intake information. Whereas, the MSQ, PROMIS Questionnaires, and Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal help gather initial symptom, function, and dietary information. • Map root causes (antecedents, triggers, mediators (ATMs)) and effects (clinical findings, current concerns) of physiological dysfunction on the Functional Medicine Timeline.
O – ORGANIZE the data gathered in the previous step and document them on the IFM Timeline and Matrix to identify the personalized root causes of current concerns, dysfunctions, and conditions, and to begin to prioritize the order (sequence) of interventions.	• Functional Medicine Tree • Functional Medicine Timeline • Functional Medicine Matrix • Adult Intake Form • Medical Symptom Questionnaire (MSQ) • PROMIS Questionnaires • Diet, Nutrition, and Lifestyle Journal	• Using the Functional Medicine Matrix, populate ATMs, clinical findings, and current concerns from the Timeline. Add modifiable lifestyle factors (MLFs) and mental, emotional, spiritual factors (MES) to support the identification of the most important areas of physiological dysfunction.
T – TELL the life story back to the patient to ensure accuracy and a shared understanding. This dialogue, focused on the Timeline, highlights how factors elicited in the Gather step may have contributed to current or future clinical findings, concerns, health status and trajectory. The patient is asked to join in correcting the story, engendering a context of true partnership.	• Functional Medicine Matrix • Functional Medicine Timeline • Functional Medicine Tree	• The Functional Medicine Timeline is used to re-tell the patient's story while correlating prior events and root causes with current concerns or conditions. Ask the patient to join in for corrections or additional context. • Use the Functional Medicine Tree to explain how the root causes have contributed to the patient's condition.

Long Description: The Essential Steps of Tell

- Toolkit item – G O T O I T – the sequence of steps used in the practice of functional medicine

The Essential Steps of “Tell”

- Explain the effects of diet and lifestyle factors as root causes.
- Ask the patient to correct and add to the story to ensure accuracy.
- Impart a positive message of hope that you will help the patient make changes so that they can begin to feel better and reach their goals.



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GOTOIT Step and Definition	IFM Tools (examples)	Clinical Actions
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Long Description: The Essential Steps of Tell

- Toolkit item – G O T O I T – the sequence of steps used in the practice of functional medicine

The Therapeutic Encounter



- Intentional
- Bidirectional
- Co-Creative

Clinical Focus:

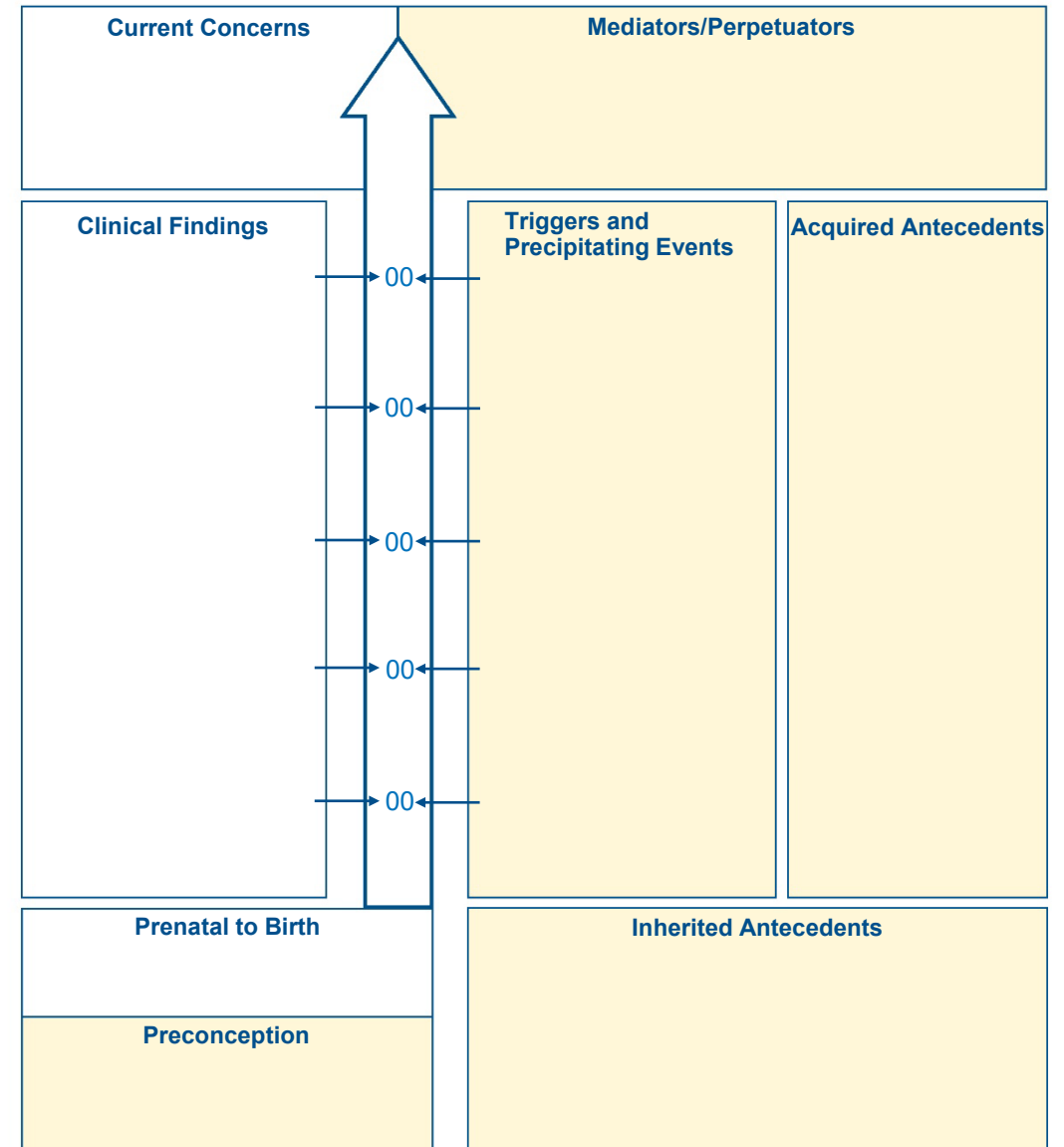
- Using the timeline to re-tell the patient's story.



Functional Medicine Timeline

ATMs Contribute to Effects of Dysfunction

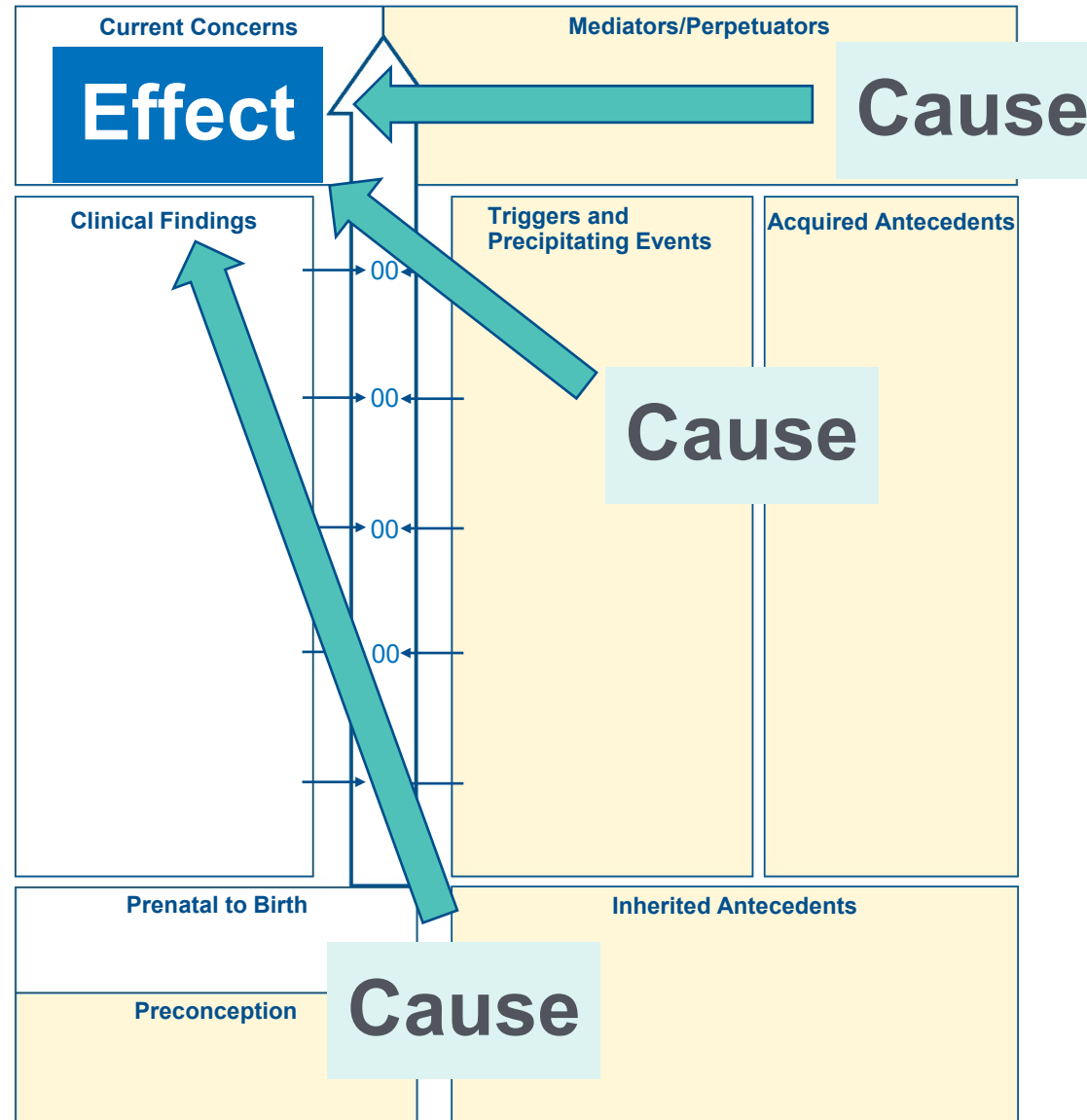
- **Antecedents** create susceptibility for dysfunction.
- **Triggers** initiate the onset of dysfunction.
- **Mediators** sustain or perpetuate dysfunction.



Long Description: ATMs Contribute to Effects of Dysfunction

- Toolkit item – Functional Medicine Timeline

Functional Medicine Timeline

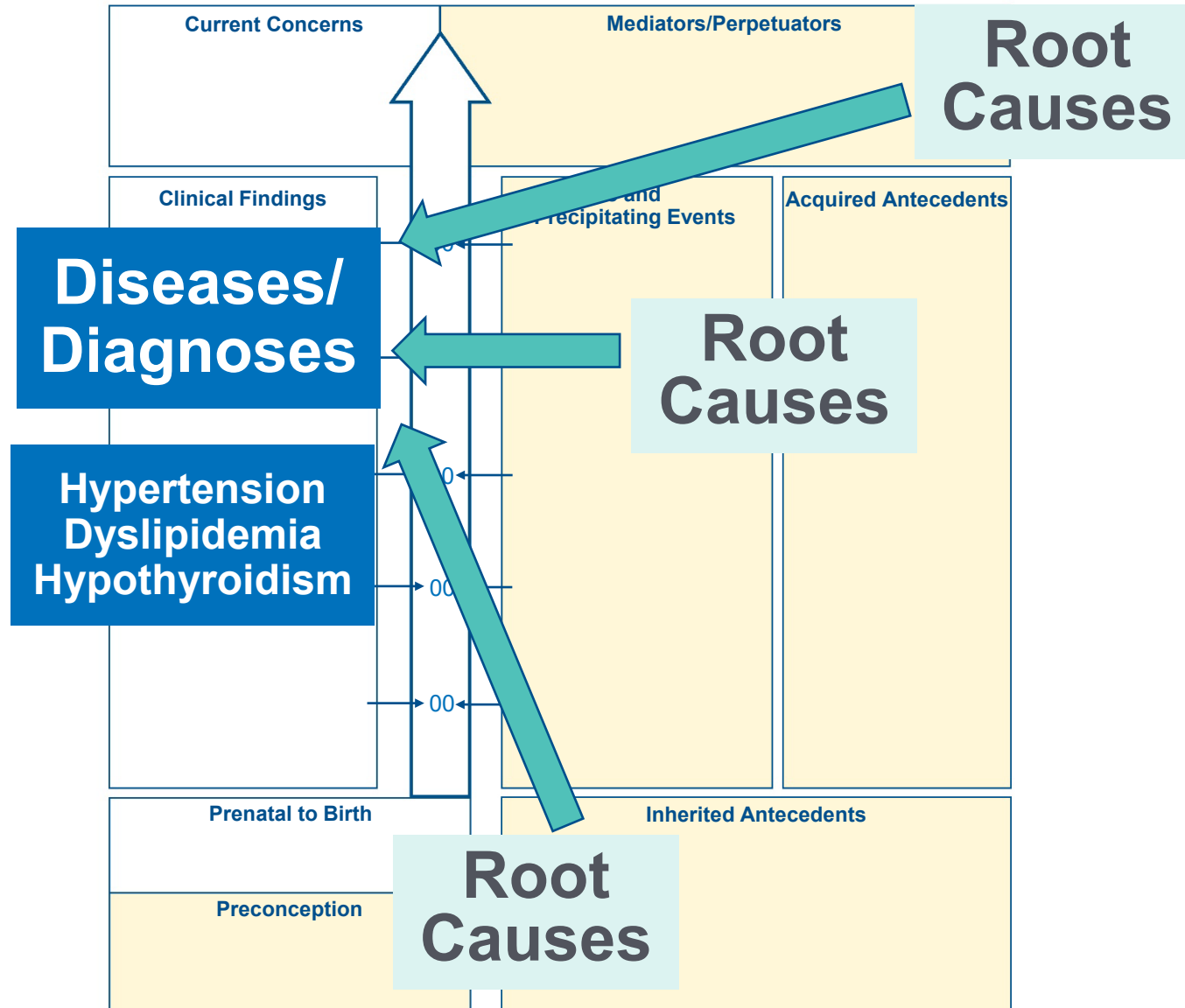


Name: _____ Date: _____ CC: _____

Long Description: The Functional Medicine Timeline

- Antecedents, triggers, and mediators are all causes of the patient's current concerns.

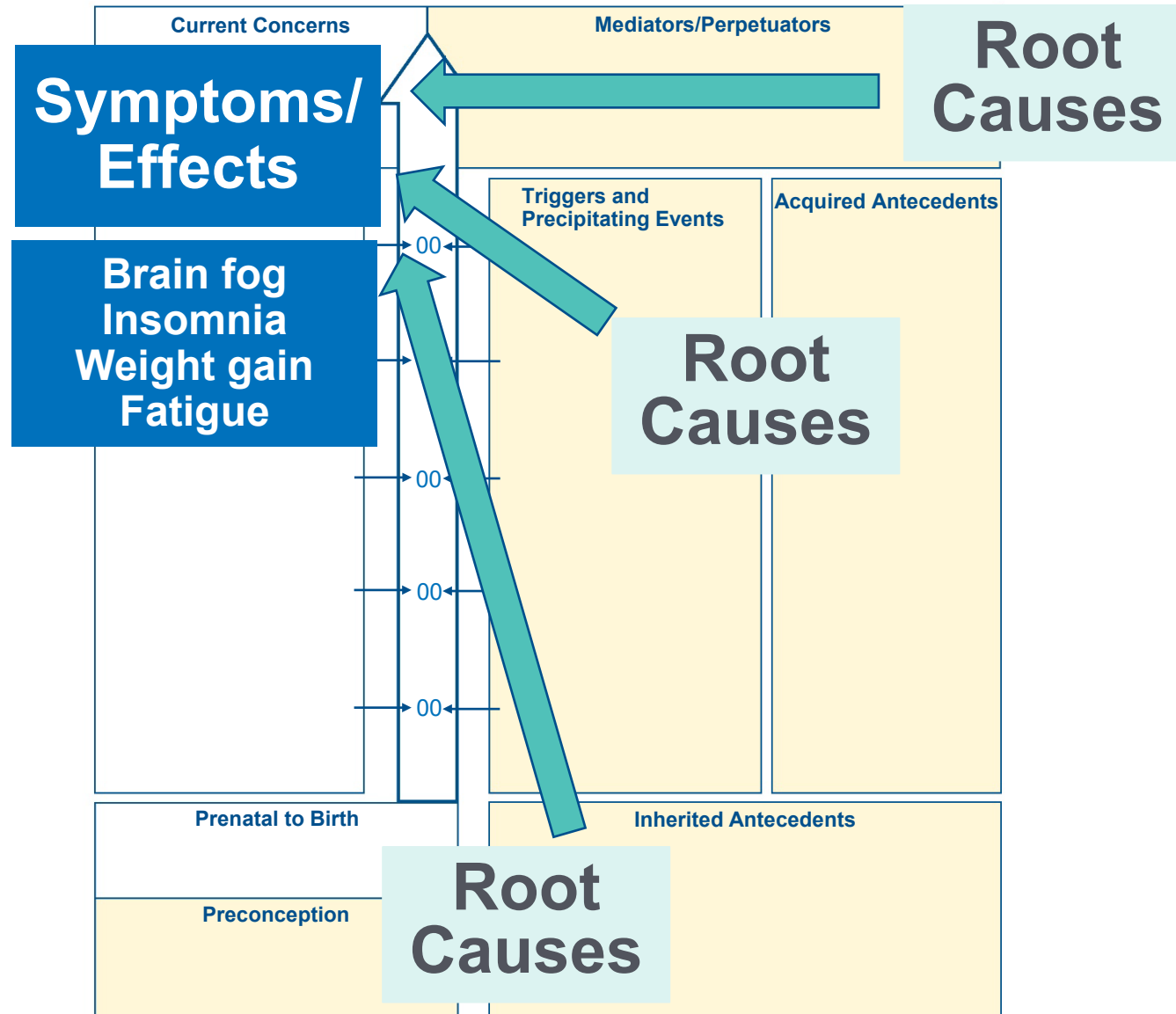
Functional Medicine Timeline



Long Description: The Functional Medicine Timeline

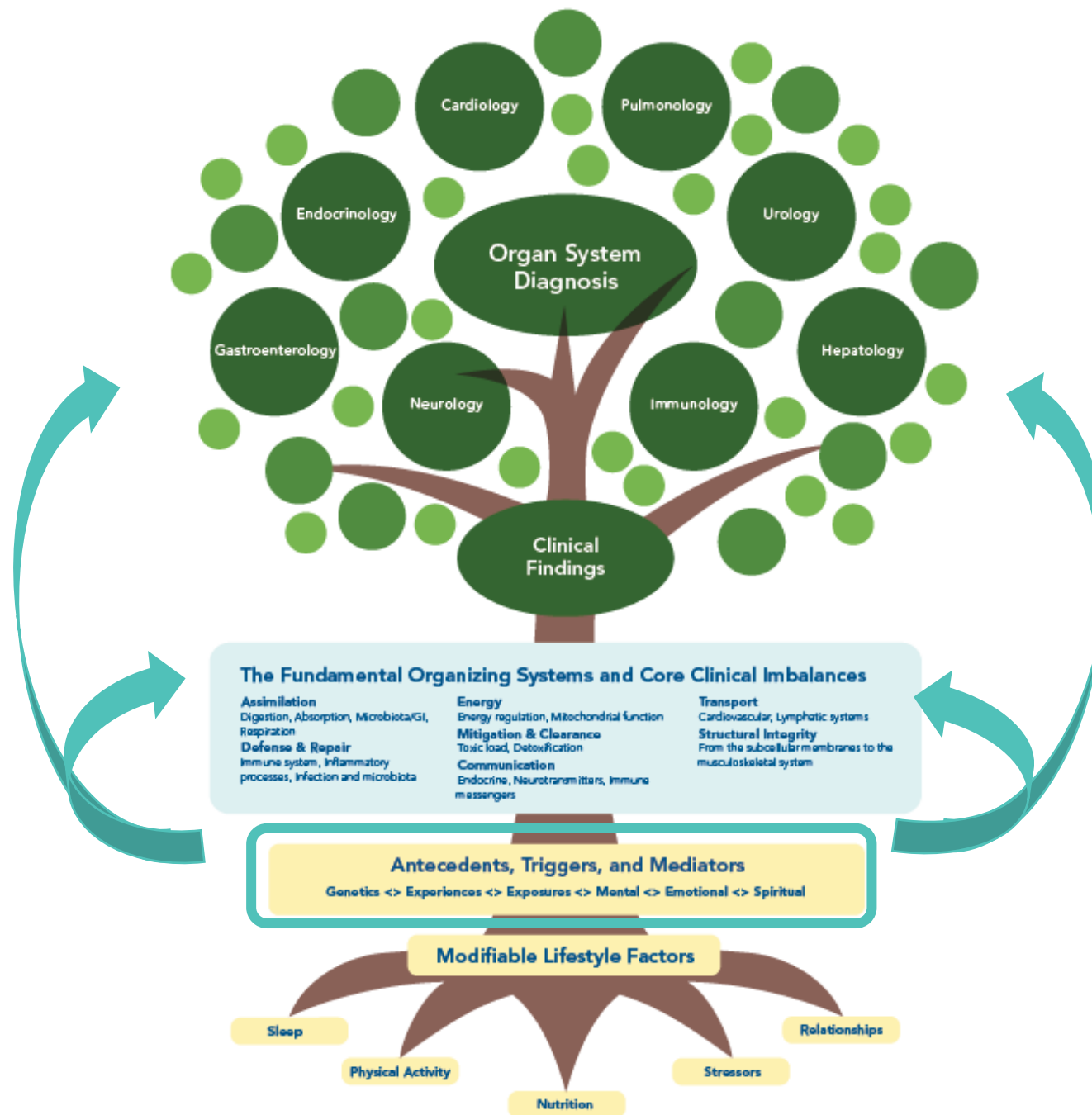
- Antecedents, triggers, and mediators are also all root causes for the patient's clinical findings, which include diseases and diagnoses. For example, hypertension, dyslipidemia, and hypothyroidism.

Functional Medicine Timeline



Long Description: The Functional Medicine Timeline

Antecedents, triggers, and mediators are also all root causes for the patient's symptoms such as brain fog, insomnia, weight gain, and fatigue.

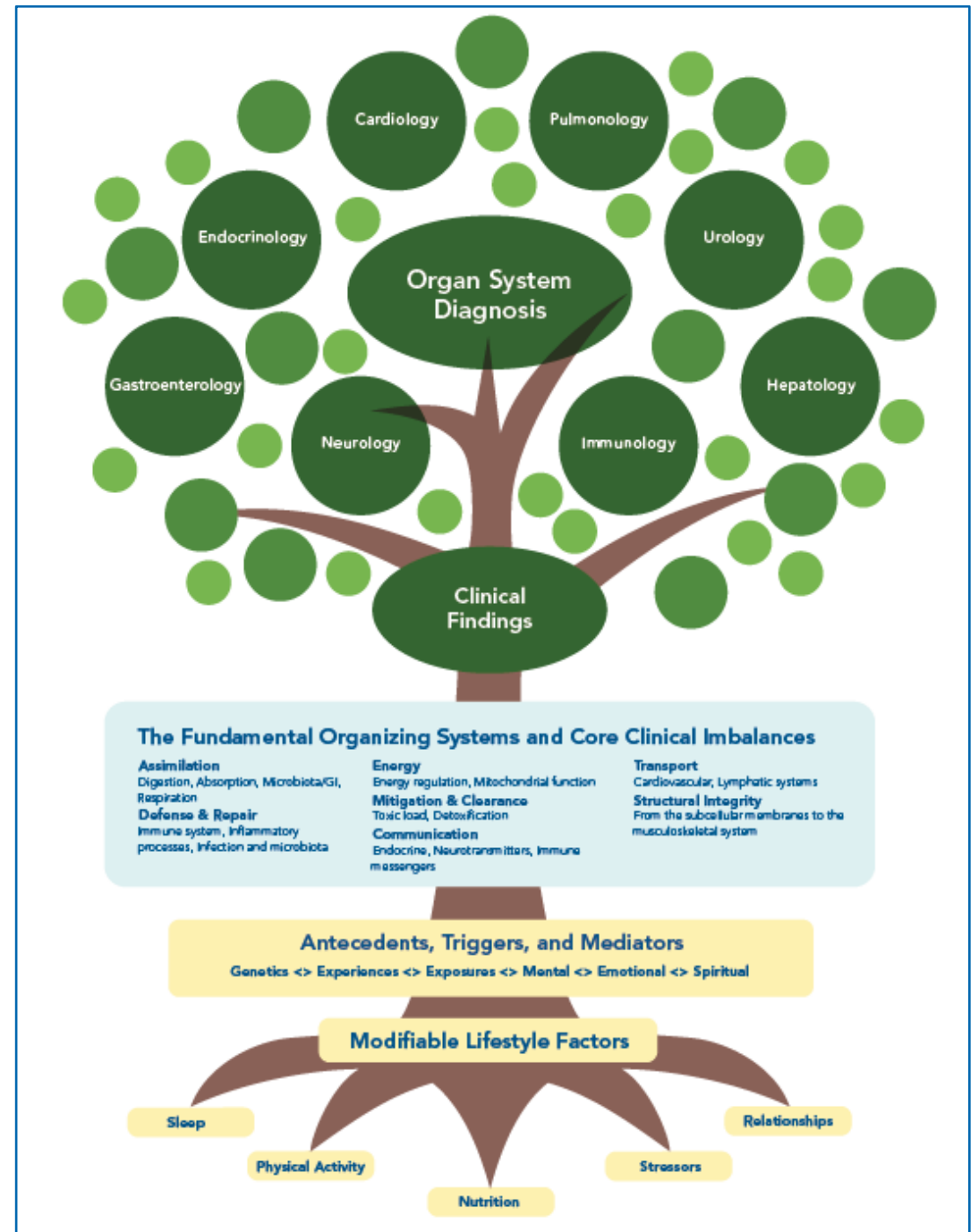


Long Description: The Functional Medicine Timeline

- Utilize modifiable lifestyle factors, diet, and mental, emotional, and spiritual nodes of the matrix to guide your understanding of the root causes. The practitioner can organize the distinguishing features of the functional medicine patient evaluation like the structure of a tree. The roots of the tree represent the modifiable lifestyle factors including sleep, physical activity, nutrition, stressors, and relationships. Moving upward, the base of the trunk represents antecedents, triggers, and mediators including genetics, epigenetics, exposures, mental health, emotional health, and spiritual health. The middle of the trunk is the fundamental organizing systems and core clinical imbalances. These are: assimilation, which includes digestion, absorption, microbiota or G I, and respiration; defense and repair, which includes the immune system, inflammatory processes, and infection and microbiota; energy, which includes energy regulation and mitochondrial function; mitigation and clearance, which includes toxic load and detoxification; communication, which includes endocrine, neurotransmitters, and immune messengers; transport, which includes cardiovascular and lymphatic systems; and structural integrity from the subcellular membranes to the musculoskeletal system. The top of the trunk represents clinical findings, and the top branches are the organ system diagnosis. The leaves represent the organ systems including neurology, gastroenterology, endocrinology, cardiology, pulmonology, urology, hepatology, and immunology.

Re-Telling the Patient's Story:

- A distinguishing feature of the functional medicine patient evaluation.
- Explain how the root causes have contributed to the patient's condition.

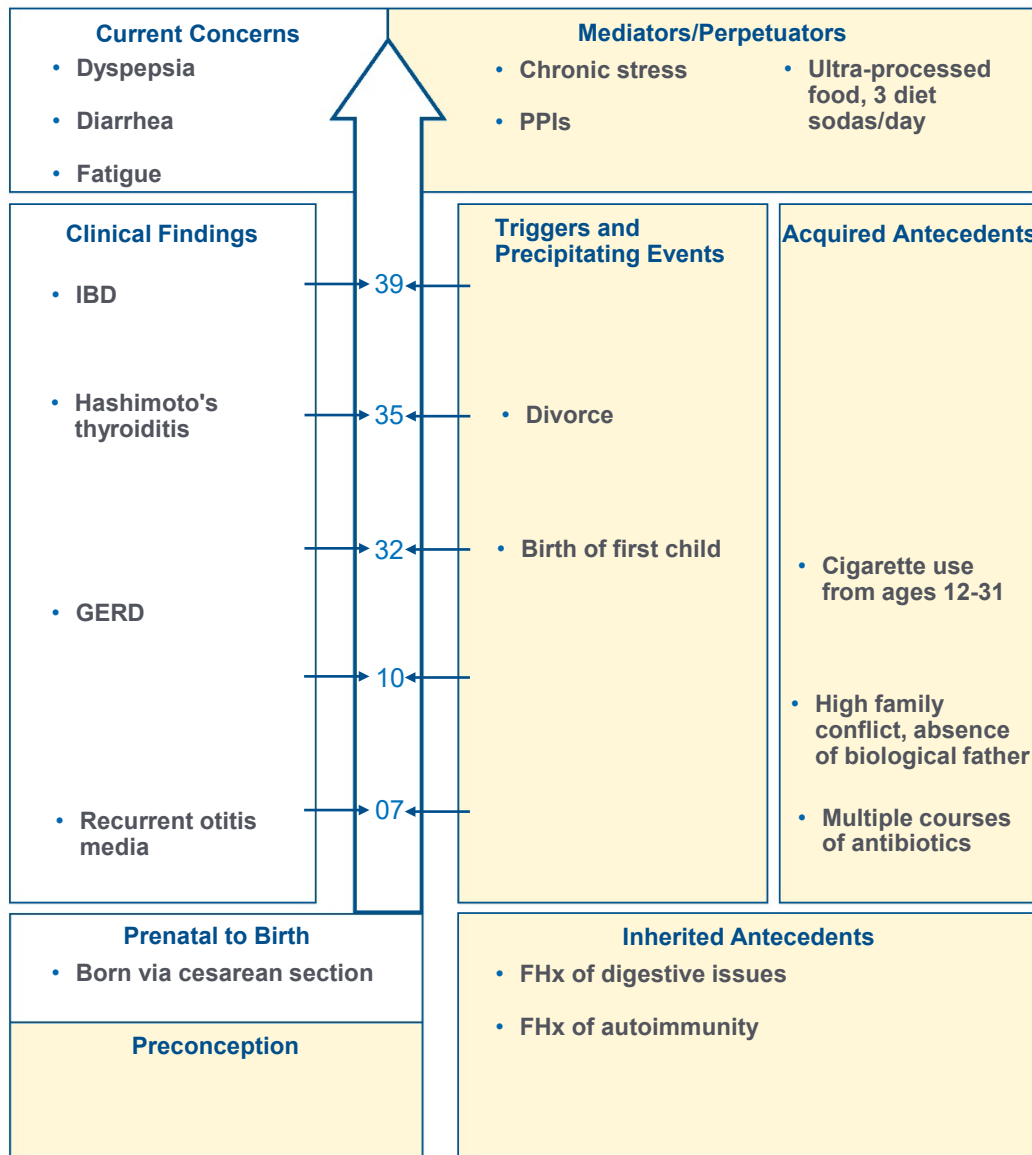


Long Description: Retelling the patient's story

- The practitioner can utilize this image of the tree discussed previously to guide them in re-telling the patient's story with an emphasis on the root causes.

Functional Medicine Timeline

Patient C
Sofia
Age 39



Name: _____ Date: _____ CC: _____

Long Description: Functional Medicine Timeline

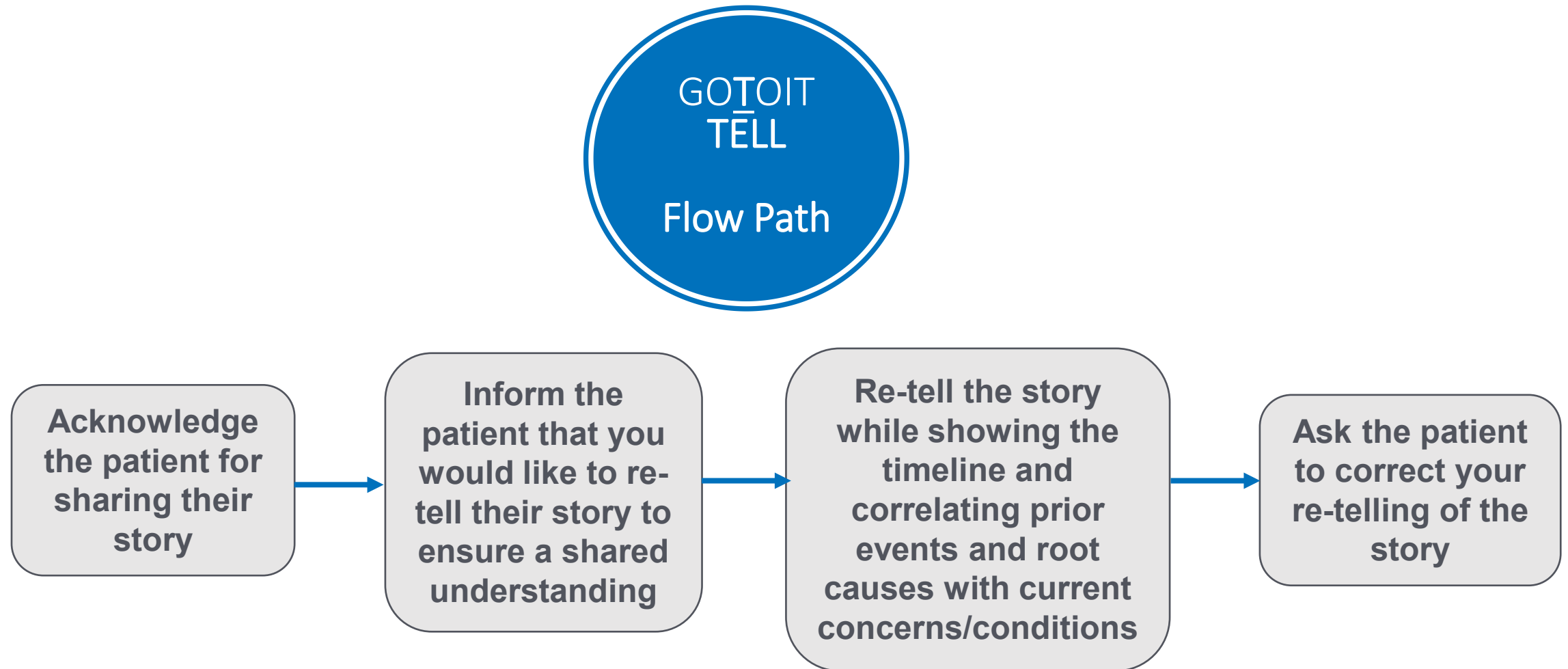
- This is a patient case example using the Functional Medicine Timeline. The patient is Sofia, a 39-year-old female. Her current concerns are dyspepsia, diarrhea, and fatigue. Clinical findings include I B D, Hashimoto's thyroiditis, G E R D, and recurrent otitis media. She was born via cesarean section. She has a family history of digestive issues and autoimmunity. Acquired antecedents include multiple courses of antibiotics in childhood, high family conflict and absence of biological father prior to 10 years old, and cigarette use from ages 12-31. Triggers and precipitating events include birth of her first child at 32 and divorce at 35. Mediators and perpetuators include chronic stress, P P I's, and ultra-processed food including 3 diet sodas per day.

Clinical Focus:

- Conclusion, key takeaways, and clinical flow path.



Key Clinical Takeaway: Flow Path for the Tell Step of GOTOIT



Long Description: Key Clinical Takeaway: Flow Path for the Tell Step of GOTOIT

- The G O T O I T tell flow path:
- Acknowledge the patient for sharing their story.
- Inform the patient that you would like to re-tell their story to ensure a shared understanding.
- Re-tell the story while showing the timeline and correlating prior events and root causes with current concerns/conditions.
- Ask the patient to correct your re-telling of the story.

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Long Description: GO TO IT Functional Medicine Framework

- By telling the patient's story to ensure a shared understanding, the practitioner prepares the patient to simultaneously prioritize the next two steps of the G O T O I T framework – order and prioritize interventions feasible for the patient and initiate referrals, evaluative tests, and therapeutic modalities.

Storytelling is therapeutic.



Being understood is the root of hope.

TELL

Re-Telling the Patient's Story

APPLYING FUNCTIONAL MEDICINE IN CLINICAL PRACTICE